

"How Long Does It Last?" — Volunteer Key

FOOD SAFETY

Chicken

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): up to 12 months frozen at 0°F

Wow: Frozen chicken can last up to 12 months with good quality, far longer than just a couple of days fresh.

Safety: Store frozen chicken at 0°F (-18°C) or below to maintain safety and quality.

Kids: Freezing makes chicken take a long nap so it stays good a really long time.

Tweens: Freezing keeps chicken so cold that the tiny bugs can't grow, making it last months.

Teens: Freezing slows down bacteria and chemical changes, preserving chicken quality for about a year.

Adult: Freezing chicken at proper temperatures halts microbial growth and enzymatic activity, maintaining safety and quality for up to 12 months.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

Winter squash (Butternut)

Fresh: 2-3 months stored at 50-55°F | Preserved (stored cured, cool and dry): 6-12 months dried or canned

Wow: Properly cured winter squash lasts months unrefrigerated, often longer than canned or frozen versions kept improperly.

Safety: Store squash in dry, well-ventilated area away from ripening fruit to avoid shortening shelf life.

Kids: A squash's skin acts like a jacket that keeps it fresh and safe for a long time.

Tweens: Curing makes squash skin tougher, helping it last longer without spoiling in cool storage.

Teens: Curing and controlled storage conditions prevent spoilage, extending the fresh life for months.

Adult: Proper curing and storage at moderate temperatures with controlled humidity extends shelf life and prevents decay.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

Tomato sauce

Fresh: 3-4 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned): up to 12 months canned in a cool, dark place

Wow: Home canned tomato sauce can last up to a year, much longer than fresh sauce in the fridge.

Safety: Store jars in a cool, dark, dry place; inspect jars before use for spoilage signs.

Kids: Canning puts sauce to sleep in a jar so it can stay good a whole year.

Tweens: Home canning seals and cooks sauce so germs can't grow, making it last months.

Teens: Heat processing and sealing eliminate bacteria and air, preserving the sauce safely for a year.

Adult: Proper heat processing and sealed storage prevent microbial growth and spoilage for extended shelf life.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

Lemon curd

Fresh: 3-4 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): 3-4 months canned, or up to 1 year frozen

Wow: Canned lemon curd lasts only a few months, but frozen curd keeps quality up to a year.

Safety: Discard any lemon curd showing browning or separation; freeze promptly after cooling for extended storage.

Kids: Lemon curd cans stay fresh for a few months, but freezing makes it sleepy for a whole year.

Tweens: Canning stops germs but lemon curd is better preserved frozen for longer freshness.

Teens: Due to delicate texture, lemon curd is best frozen for extended storage rather than canned long-term.

Adult: Acid and heat treatment preserve lemon curd for months canned; freezing better maintains texture and quality longer.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

Smoked Seafood

Fresh: 1-3 days refrigerated fresh | Preserved (refrigerated, smoked): 2-3 weeks refrigerated smoked

Wow: Smoked seafood lasts only a few weeks refrigerated, much shorter than frozen seafood, despite the smoking process.

Safety: Smoked seafood is perishable and should not be refrigerated longer than 2-3 weeks; freezing is recommended for longer storage.

Kids: Smoking is like giving fish a special coat that helps it stay good for some days, but it can still go bad after a few weeks.

Tweens: Smoking seafood slows how fast it goes bad but it still can spoil in a few weeks if kept just in the fridge.

Teens: Smoking seafood preserves it by adding flavor and some protection, but because it's moist, it only stays safe for a few weeks refrigerated.

Adult: While smoking imparts flavor and partially preserves seafood, refrigerated smoked seafood remains perishable with a safe shelf life of just 2-3 weeks; freezing is better for long-term.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

CANNING FRUITS

Peaches

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months home canned

Wow: Fresh peaches last only days refrigerated, but canned peaches can keep best quality for over a year.

Safety: Store home canned peaches in a cool, dark place; exposure to heat or light reduces quality and shelf life.

Kids: When canned, peaches get sleepy inside jars and can stay tasty for a long time, much longer than fresh peaches in the fridge.

Tweens: Canning peaches slows down the spoiling by trapping heat and sealing out air, so they stay good much longer than fresh ones in your fridge.

Teens: Peaches lose freshness quickly due to enzyme activity and microbes, but home canning stops them by heat and sealing, extending shelf life well beyond fresh storage.

Adult: Canning peaches using boiling water bath preserves them by heat sterilization and vacuum sealing, thus maintaining safety and quality for 12-18 months under proper cool storage, unlike fresh peaches which deteriorate in days refrigerated.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

Elderberry Jam

Fresh: 1 week refrigerated | Preserved (home canned high-sugar jam): 12 months home canned

Wow: Elderberry jam must have a high sugar ratio to be safe when canned; the sugar keeps bad bacteria from growing.

Safety: Follow exact sugar ratios and processing times when making elderberry jams to prevent botulism risk.

Kids: Sugar in the jam helps keep tiny bad bugs away so the jam stays safe for a long time in the jar.

Tweens: The high sugar level reduces moisture for bacteria to grow, making canned elderberry jam safe to store for a year.

Teens: By reducing water activity with lots of sugar and proper heating, elderberry jam can be safely canned and stored up to a year.

Adult: American and European elderberries require precise sugar ratios in jams to reduce water activity sufficiently for safe home canning to 12 months, preventing *Clostridium botulinum* growth.

Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries

Pears

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months home canned

Wow: Home canned pears can be stored safely up to 18 months, but fresh pears spoil in under a week even refrigerated.

Safety: Store canned pears in cool, dry conditions away from heat and light for best quality.

Kids: Canning pears is like putting them to sleep in jars so they last way longer than fresh pears in the fridge.

Tweens: Canning slows down spoiling by sealing pears in air-tight jars after heating, extending their life from a few days to over a year.

Teens: Heat processing kills microbes, and a sealed jar locks out oxygen, so canned pears maintain safety and quality longer than fresh refrigerated ones.

Adult: Pears canned using proper heat processing and sealed jars maintain microbiological safety and quality up to 18 months stored in ideal conditions, versus 5-7 days fresh refrigerated.

Source: SP 50-678 Preserving pears

Plums

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months home canned

Wow: Fresh plums go bad in under a week refrigerated, but canned plums stay good for over a year.

Safety: Keep canned plums away from direct heat or freezing to maintain shelf life and quality.

Kids: The plums stay good for a long time because they are kept in special jars that keep air out.

Tweens: The canning process heats and seals plums so microbes can't grow, making them last much longer than fresh plums alone.

Teens: Heat sterilization and vacuum sealing extend canned plums' shelf life far beyond fresh refrigerated storage by inhibiting spoilage and pathogens.

Adult: Home canned plums retain safety and quality for 12-18 months because heat processing eliminates spoilage organisms and the vacuum seal prevents recontamination, unlike fresh plums which perish within days refrigerated.

Source: SP 50-586 Preserving plums and prunes

Berries

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12 months home canned

Wow: Though berries are very perishable fresh, canned berries can remain good quality for a full year.

Safety: Store home canned berries in cool, dark, dry conditions to prevent spoilage and quality loss.

Kids: Berries in a jar stay yummy for a long time because they are kept safe inside the jar.

Tweens: Canning kills the germs and closes the jars tight, so berries stay safe and yummy way longer than fresh ones in the fridge.
Teens: Water bath canning inactivates spoilage microbes and seals the berries in sterile jars, greatly extending their shelf life.
Adult: Home canned berries maintain microbiological safety and quality for about 12 months with proper heat processing and cool storage, compared to 3-5 days fresh refrigerated.
Source: SP 50-780 Preserving berries

CANNING TOMATOES & SALSAS

Fresh tomatoes

Fresh: about 1 week refrigerated | **Preserved (home canned (pressure canner)):** 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Home canned tomatoes last over a year, vastly outlasting their fresh refrigerated life.

Safety: Use tested recipes and process tomato products in a pressure canner at recommended pressures and times.

Kids: Canning makes tomatoes cozy and sleepy so they stay good a long time.

Tweens: Canning stops bacteria by heating, so canned tomatoes last much longer than fresh ones.

Teens: Pressure canning kills germs and seals jars so tomatoes stay safe and tasty for over a year.

Adult: Pressure canning destroys spoilage microbes and preserves acidity, ensuring storage for 12-18 months safely.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

Fresh salsa (homemade refrigerator)

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | **Preserved (home canned salsa (boiling water canner)):** 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Though fresh salsa spoils in days, the same ingredients canned properly last over a year safely.

Safety: Boiling water canning with tested recipes is critical; process times depend on altitude and acidity.

Kids: Fresh salsa goes bad fast, but canning makes it last a long time like magic jars.

Tweens: Canned salsa is heated and sealed in jars to keep it fresh for a long time, but fresh salsa in the fridge stays good only for a few days.

Teens: Proper canning kills microbes and uses vinegar acid so salsa stays shelf stable for over a year.

Adult: Boiling water canning combined with acidification and proper processing times ensures salsa safety and long shelf life.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

Spaghetti sauce without meat

Fresh: about 5-7 days refrigerated | **Preserved (home canned (pressure canner)):** 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Canned spaghetti sauce made without meat keeps safely over a year, much longer than fresh sauce in the fridge.

Safety: Do not increase proportion of low acid vegetables; process in a pressure canner at 20-25 minutes depending on jar size.

Kids: Canning makes spaghetti sauce last longer by keeping it safe inside the jar.

Tweens: Pressure canning heats sauce high enough to kill germs and seal them out, so sauce lasts months.

Teens: Properly pressure canned spaghetti sauce keeps safe by destroying microbes and sealing air out for long storage.

Adult: Pressure canning times and pressure ensure microbiological safety for vegetable-tomato blends, extending shelf life well beyond fresh.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

Tomato salsa (using paste tomatoes)

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | **Preserved (home canned (boiling water canner)):** 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Tomato salsa made with paste tomatoes lasts a few days fresh but over a year canned safely.

Safety: Use tested recipes and vinegar levels; process 15-25 minutes in boiling water canner based on altitude.

Kids: Fresh salsa goes bad quick but canned salsa stays good for a long time.

Tweens: Canning salsa with vinegar and heat makes it last long and stops germs.

Teens: The acidity plus boiling water canning kills microbes so salsa keeps edible for a year or more.

Adult: Acid and proper boiling water canning processing ensure safe long-term storage of tomato-based salsas.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

Tomatoes with okra or zucchini

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated | **Preserved (home canned (pressure canner)):** 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Adding okra or zucchini to canned tomatoes does not shorten shelf life if processed properly.

Safety: Process in pressure canner; added vegetables require careful adherence to tested recipes and processing times.

Kids: Even with extra veggies, canned tomatoes can last a long time safe in jars.

Tweens: Pressure canning tomatoes mixed with okra or zucchini keeps bacteria away so it lasts months.

Teens: The pressure canner destroys microbes and seals the mix, preserving it safely for over a year.

Adult: Pressure canning tomato mixes with additional vegetables maintains safety and shelf life if processing times are followed.

LOW ACID FOODS

Green Beans

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (pressure canner)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Home-canned green beans last almost 3 years safe, far longer than fresh refrigerated beans last about a week.

Safety: Use pressure canning to destroy *Clostridium botulinum* spores; boiling water canner is unsafe for low acid vegetables.

Kids: Canning green beans uses special heat to stop germs, so they stay safe much longer than fresh.

Tweens: Pressure canning heats green beans enough to kill bad germs, letting them last way longer than fresh beans in the fridge.

Teens: Green beans have low acid, so they need pressure canning to be safely preserved for over a year compared to about a week fresh.

Adult: Due to their low acidity, green beans must be pressure canned to safely destroy botulism spores, allowing safe storage for 12-18 months versus a few days fresh.

Source: SP 50-445 Preserving green italian or wax beans

Sweet Corn

Fresh: 1-3 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (pressure canner)): 12-18 months, home canned

Wow: Fresh sweet corn loses quality within days, but home-canned corn stays good and safe for about 1.5 years.

Safety: Always use pressure canning for corn to prevent botulism; refrigerator storage extends freshness only a few days.

Kids: Canned corn is cooked in a special pot to keep it from going bad for a really long time.

Tweens: Because corn is low acid, pressure canning kills germs so corn lasts over a year unlike fresh corn that goes bad fast.

Teens: Sweet corn's low acidity requires pressure canning to ensure long-term safety, extending its shelf life from a few days fresh to over a year preserved.

Adult: Sweet corn is low acid, requiring pressure canning to eliminate *Clostridium botulinum* risks, making it safe for 12-18 months storage, much longer than fresh corn.

Source: SP 50-443 Preserving corn

Fresh Peas

Fresh: 2-3 days refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): 8-12 months frozen

Wow: Freezing fresh peas preserves their best quality for almost a year, far longer than just a few days fresh.

Safety: Freeze promptly after blanching for best quality; freezing does not kill all microbes but stops their growth.

Kids: Freezing peas puts them to sleep so they don't go bad for a really long time.

Tweens: Freezing peas slows germs down so peas stay fresh up to a year, much longer than only a few days fresh in the fridge.

Teens: Freezing slows down microbes and enzyme activity, extending pea quality from a few days fresh to nearly a year frozen.

Adult: Blanching then freezing peas halts microbial and enzymatic spoilage processes, allowing quality retention up to a year versus days fresh.

Source: SP 50-305 Preserving peas edible pea pods

Pumpkin (cubed)

Fresh: 3-4 days refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): 10-12 months frozen

Wow: Cubed pumpkin freezes well for nearly a year, significantly extending its use beyond just a few days fresh.

Safety: Blanch cubes before freezing for best quality; frozen pumpkin remains safe past quality loss if kept frozen.

Kids: Pumpkin stays good in the freezer because the cold stops it from going bad quickly.

Tweens: Freezing pumpkin slows down spoiling and keeps it good for almost a year compared to a few days fresh.

Teens: Frozen pumpkin preserves nutrients and slows spoilage compared to fresh, extending use up to a year.

Adult: Blanching and freezing pumpkin cubes maintains quality and safety for up to a year, far longer than a few days refrigerated.

Source: SP 50-767 Preserving pumpkins winter squash

Garlic

Fresh: 1 week refrigerated | Preserved (frozen chopped): 3-6 months frozen

Wow: Fresh garlic can last about a week refrigerated, but freezing chopped garlic keeps its flavor safe up to half a year.

Safety: Use airtight containers or vacuum sealing for freezing to avoid freezer burn; garlic in oil must be refrigerated and used quickly.

Kids: Freezing garlic keeps it cold so it stays tasty for a long time.

Tweens: Chopped garlic frozen in small amounts lasts months because cold stops it from spoiling quickly.

Teens: Freezing garlic extends storage by slowing microbial growth and oxidation compared to fresh garlic's 1-week fridge life.

Adult: Garlic freezes well to preserve flavor and safety for months, whereas fresh garlic keeps about a week refrigerated under ideal conditions.

PICKLING

Cucumbers (pickled)

Fresh: about 1 week refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): up to 1 year stored in a cool, dark, dry place

Wow: Pickled cucumbers can last up to a year, vastly outliving their fresh lifespan of about a week.

Safety: Store jars in a cool, dark, dry place; remove screw bands to prevent rusting; use proper vinegar acidity to prevent bacterial growth.

Kids: Pickling puts cucumbers to sleep in a special salty and vinegary juice so they stay good much longer.

Tweens: Pickling uses vinegar and salt to stop germs from growing, so pickles keep good for many months.

Teens: The acid and processing in pickling jars prevent bacteria and molds, preserving cucumbers far beyond their fresh life.

Adult: Acidic preservation combined with heat processing inhibits pathogenic bacteria, allowing safe storage of pickled cucumbers up to a year with maintained quality.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Bread and Butter Pickles

Fresh: 5-7 days refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): up to 1 year in pantry storage

Wow: Bread and Butter Pickles transform fresh zucchini or cucumbers lasting days into a pantry staple lasting a year or more.

Safety: Use proper vinegar concentration and processing times; keep stored away from heat and light to preserve quality.

Kids: Cooking pickles with sugar and vinegar helps them stay yummy and safe for a long time in jars.

Tweens: The sweet and sour pickling vinegar stop germs and let these pickles last much longer than fresh veggies.

Teens: The sugar-vinegar solution combined with canning heat kills spoilage organisms and extends shelf life drastically.

Adult: Proper hot-pack canning with acidic vinegar and heat ensures preservation of bread and butter pickles for approximately a year.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Pickled Hot Peppers

Fresh: about 1 week refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): up to 1 year shelf stable

Wow: Hot peppers, though fresh for just a week, become shelf stable for up to a year once pickled correctly.

Safety: Wear gloves handling hot peppers; process in boiling water bath according to altitude and jar size to ensure safety.

Kids: The vinegar and heat keep peppers safe so they can last a very long time in jars without spoiling.

Tweens: Acidic pickling juice and canning kill germs so hot peppers last months without going bad.

Teens: Pickling peppers in acid and processing kills harmful bacteria, extending their shelf life well beyond fresh.

Adult: Following recommended boiling water bath processing times, pickled peppers achieve safe, long-term shelf stability.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Fermented Sauerkraut

Fresh: fresh cabbage lasts 2-3 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (fermentation (brined)): fermented sauerkraut can last for 4-6 months refrigerated

Wow: Fermented sauerkraut lasts many months longer than fresh cabbage thanks to friendly bacteria producing acid.

Safety: Keep sauerkraut submerged in brine during fermentation; store refrigerated to prevent spoilage.

Kids: Good tiny bugs in sauerkraut juice keep it fresh and tasty for many months.

Tweens: Sauerkraut is made with helpful bacteria that make acid, stopping bad germs and keeping it fresh longer.

Teens: Lactic acid bacteria fermentation creates an acidic environment so sauerkraut remains safe and edible for months refrigerated.

Adult: Fermentation drives acid production that inhibits pathogens, extending shelf life well beyond fresh cabbage under refrigeration.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

Pickled Onions

Fresh: fresh onions last 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (home canned (boiling water bath)): up to 1 year shelf stable

Wow: Pickled onions keep safe and tasty for up to a year, while fresh onions spoil within a couple of weeks.

Safety: Use approved pickling recipe with sufficient vinegar; process jars fully to prevent spoilage and botulism risk.

Kids: Vinegar and cooking make onions stay good in jars for a very long time.

Tweens: The sour vinegar and hot water bath kill germs so onions don't spoil for many months.

Teens: Processing pickled onions with vinegar and heat prevents bacterial growth and prolongs shelf life greatly.

Adult: Proper acidification and heat processing create stable conditions that extend pickled onions' storage life up to one year.
Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

JAMS & JELLIES

Strawberry Freezer Jam

Fresh: 1-3 days refrigerated | Preserved (frozen (freezer)): up to 1 year frozen

Wow: Freezing jams preserves both flavor and texture much longer than refrigerating fresh jam, which spoils quickly.

Safety: Freezer jams are not heat processed; must be kept frozen or refrigerated and used within recommended times.

Kids: Freezing makes jam sleepy so it stays good way longer than if you just keep it cold in the fridge.

Tweens: Freezing slows down bacteria and mold, keeping the jam fresh for months instead of days.

Teens: Freezing reduces chemical and microbial activity, preserving the fresh taste and texture far beyond refrigeration.

Adult: Freezing maintains jam quality by halting spoilage organisms and slowing enzymatic reactions, extending shelf life substantially.

Source: SP 50-763 Uncooked freezer jams

Grape Jam

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated fresh | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months home canned

Wow: Properly canned grape jam can last over a year, far longer than fresh jam which spoils in less than a week.

Safety: Follow exact canning times and headspace recommendations precisely to ensure safety and avoid spoilage.

Kids: Canning puts jam into a safe jar that keeps it fresh much longer than just putting it in the fridge.

Tweens: The jam stays good for a long time because grown-ups heat it to keep germs out and close the jar tightly.

Teens: Water bath canning heats the jam to destroy microbes and create a vacuum seal that preserves it safely for 12-18 months.

Adult: Processing grape jam in a boiling water canner destroys spoilage organisms and yeast, extending shelf life up to 18 months.

Source: SP 50-777 Jams jellies preserves with no added pectin

Blackberry Jelly

Fresh: 2-4 days refrigerated fresh juice/jelly | Preserved (home canned (water bath)): 12-18 months home canned jelly

Wow: Blackberry jelly, when canned properly, can keep safely for over a year, in contrast to fresh juice which spoils in a few days.

Safety: Use only tested recipes and ensure jelly reaches gelling point and process times to maintain safety.

Kids: Canning locks the jelly away in jars that keep it fresh a very long time compared to fresh juice that goes bad quickly.

Tweens: The jelly stays good for a long time because grown-ups heat the jars carefully to keep it safe inside.

Teens: Water bath canning involves boiling jars to kill microbes and create a vacuum seal that preserves the jelly safely long-term.

Adult: Proper pressure or water bath canning of blackberry jelly ensures destruction of spoilage microorganisms and vacuum seal storage.

Source: SP 50-777 Jams jellies preserves with no added pectin

No-Sugar Added Fruit Spread

Fresh: 3-5 days refrigerated fresh | Preserved (home canned (water bath, low sugar recipes)): 6-12 months home canned low sugar

Wow: Low sugar fruit spreads require careful processing and have a shorter shelf life than traditional jams with high sugar.

Safety: Low sugar spreads need tested recipes and proper acidification to ensure safety during canning.

Kids: Without a lot of sugar, jam needs extra care to keep it safe and fresh for a shorter time.

Tweens: The fruit spread stays good for a while because it is sealed tightly so air and germs can't get in.

Teens: Sugar acts as a preservative by lowering water activity; less sugar means shorter safe shelf life needing vigilant processing.

Adult: Reduced sugar formulations increase water activity, requiring precise acid addition and canning to inhibit microbial growth and ensure safety.

Source: SP 50-765 Low sugar fruit spreads

High-Sugar Elderberry Jam

Fresh: 3-4 days refrigerated fresh | Preserved (home canned (water bath, high sugar ratio)): 12-18 months home canned high sugar jam

Wow: Elderberry jams must have very high sugar levels to be safely canned because of their low natural acidity.

Safety: Must strictly follow sugar-to-juice ratios and processing times to prevent risk from botulism.

Kids: Elderberry jam uses lots of sugar to keep it safe and last a long time in jars.

Tweens: Because elderberries aren't very sour, more sugar is needed in jam to stop germs from growing.

Teens: High sugar concentration reduces water activity, making low-acid elderberry jam safe for water-bath canning if done

properly.

Adult: Elderberry jams with pH >4.6 rely on high sugar content to safely inhibit *Clostridium botulinum* growth during canning.

Source: EM 9446 *Playing it safe when preserving elderberries*

FREEZING & COLD STORAGE

Fresh Mushrooms

Fresh: 1-3 days refrigerated | Preserved (refrigerated): up to 12 months frozen

Wow: Fresh mushrooms only last a couple days refrigerated, but they can be frozen up to a year for long storage.

Safety: Keep mushrooms dry and store in refrigerator to delay spoilage; freeze if storing long term.

Kids: Fresh mushrooms get tired quickly in the fridge, but freezing makes them rest for much longer.

Tweens: Fresh mushrooms spoil fast because wetness and air make them go bad, but freezing slows this way down.

Teens: Mushrooms kept fresh only last a few days refrigerated, but freezing halts spoilage processes extending storage up to a year.

Adult: Fresh mushrooms have short refrigerated life due to moisture and microbial activity; freezing halts decay, allowing storage near a year with quality loss minimized.

Source: EM 9331 *Survival basics food*

Eggs

Fresh: 3-5 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (fresh refrigerated): months to years stored in water glass (lime water)

Wow: Storing eggs in water glass can preserve them for many months, far longer than typical refrigeration.

Safety: Commercial eggs are washed and must be refrigerated; improper storage or washing decreases shelf life.

Kids: Eggs stay fresh longer when they are kept cool in the fridge.

Tweens: The special way eggs are kept stops air from getting in, so they stay fresh longer in the fridge.

Teens: Using lime water (water glass) to store eggs is an old method extending shelf life compared to standard refrigeration.

Adult: Storing eggs in water glass forms a protective seal slowing bacterial penetration, extending storage months beyond refrigerated shelf life.

Source: EM 9331 *Survival basics food*

Fresh Fish (Salmon)

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated | Preserved (fresh refrigerated): up to 3 months frozen

Wow: Fresh salmon spoils fast in the fridge but can keep good quality only up to 3 months frozen.

Safety: Freeze at 0°F or colder; avoid slow freezing to reduce ice crystal damage; cook immediately after thawing.

Kids: Fresh fish goes bad quickly, but freezing puts it to sleep so it can last longer.

Tweens: Freezing fish slows things that make it go bad, but only for a few months for best taste.

Teens: Home freezing salmon extends shelf life from days to months, but texture and flavor may decrease after 3 months.

Adult: Salmon has very limited refrigerated life but freezing at 0°F slows enzyme and microbial action, maintaining quality about 3 months at home freezer standards.

Source: PNW 586 *Home freezing seafood*

Cooked Meat Casserole

Fresh: 3-4 days refrigerated | Preserved (frozen): 4-6 months frozen

Wow: A cooked meat casserole lasts just days in the fridge but can be kept frozen for half a year.

Safety: Freeze promptly in airtight packaging; store at 0°F or lower for best quality.

Kids: Cooked meat in the fridge goes bad fast, but freezing keeps it safe and tasty longer.

Tweens: Freezing keeps cooked meat casserole good by making germs stop growing.

Teens: Cooked meat casseroles spoil quickly refrigerated; freezing stops spoilage extending storage about 6 months.

Adult: Cooked meat dishes deteriorate rapidly refrigerated; freezing halts microbiological activity extending quality storage about 4-6 months.

Source: PNW 296 *Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home*

Acorn squash

Fresh: 1-2 months in cool storage at 50-55°F | Preserved (frozen): 8-12 months frozen at 0°F

Wow: Acorn squash lasts just 1-2 months fresh in cool storage but can be frozen and retain quality for up to a year.

Safety: Store fresh squash at 50-55°F to avoid rapid deterioration; freezing stops spoilage but quality declines if frozen too long.

Kids: Fresh acorn squash stays good in a cool place for a while, but freezing makes it sleepy so it stays fresh much longer.

Tweens: When fresh, acorn squash lasts a couple months if kept cool, but freezing really slows down the spoiling so it lasts many months more.

Teens: Fresh acorn squash can be stored for about 1-2 months in a cool environment, but freezing it at 0°F preserves it and extends its lifespan to nearly a year.

Adult: Acorn squash stored fresh at 50-55°F lasts 1-2 months, while freezing it at 0°F maintains quality for 8-12 months by halting microbial growth and enzymatic changes.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

DEHYDRATING & SMOKING

Beef Jerky

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated | Preserved (dried): 1-2 months at room temperature, up to 6 months refrigerated, or 1 year frozen

Wow: Homemade beef jerky can last almost a year if frozen, vastly outlasting fresh meat's brief refrigerated life.

Safety: Store jerky in a cool, dark, dry place; discard if mold appears.

Kids: Drying jerky takes away moisture so tiny germs can't grow and spoil it.

Tweens: Removing water from jerky stops bacteria and mold from growing, keeping it safe longer.

Teens: Drying jerky dehydrates it, which prevents microbial growth, extending its edible life far beyond fresh meat.

Adult: Dehydration reduces water activity preventing spoilage microorganisms; proper storage conditions significantly extend shelf life.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

Smoked Sausage

Fresh: 1-2 days refrigerated | Preserved (smoked): 2-3 weeks refrigerated vacuum sealed

Wow: Smoking extends sausage shelf life modestly-weeks, not months-so refrigeration remains essential.

Safety: Keep smoked sausage refrigerated and vacuum-sealed for best quality and safety.

Kids: Smoking helps keep sausage good a little longer by drying and adding smoke's special stuff.

Tweens: Smoking cures meat a bit, slowing bacteria so the sausage stays safe for weeks if kept cold.

Teens: Smoking applies heat and smoke compounds that preserve the meat, but refrigeration is still critical.

Adult: Smoking adds preservative smoke chemicals and partially dries the sausage, extending refrigerated shelf life but not indefinitely.

Source: SP 50-735 Summer sausage deli style meats

Dried Herbs

Fresh: 1-2 weeks fresh at room temperature | Preserved (dried): 1-3 years dried in airtight container

Wow: Dry herbs retain flavor and safety for years, while fresh herbs spoil in days.

Safety: Store dried herbs in airtight containers away from light and moisture for best quality.

Kids: Drying herbs takes away water so they don't rot and stay good a long time.

Tweens: Removing moisture stops germs from growing, so dried herbs can last years.

Teens: Dried herbs have low water activity preventing spoilage microbes; cool, airtight storage preserves flavor years.

Adult: Herbs dried to brittle dryness and stored airtight at room temperature retain quality and safety for up to 3 years.

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

Smoked Bacon

Fresh: 1 week refrigerated fresh | Preserved (smoked and cured): 1-2 months refrigerated smoked and cured

Wow: Smoking combined with curing roughly triples the shelf life of bacon under refrigeration.

Safety: Keep smoked bacon refrigerated and use within recommended time; discard if off odor or slime appear.

Kids: Smoking and curing bacon help keep it from spoiling as fast by keeping germs away.

Tweens: Smoking adds smoke and salt that slow spoilage germs, so bacon lasts weeks refrigerated.

Teens: Smoking and curing reduce moisture and add antimicrobials, increasing safety and shelf life refrigerated.

Adult: Curing salts plus smoking inhibit microbial growth, extending refrigerated bacon shelf life significantly over fresh.

Source: PNW 784 Making bacon at home

Dried Peppers

Fresh: 1-2 weeks refrigerated | Preserved (dried): 6 months to 1 year dried in airtight container

Wow: Dried peppers last many months at room temperature, far longer than fresh ones which spoil in weeks.

Safety: Store dried peppers in a cool, dry, dark place in sealed containers to prevent spoilage.

Kids: Taking water out of peppers stops them from rotting, so they last much longer.

Tweens: Drying peppers removes water, which prevents bacteria and mold from growing for many months.

Teens: Dehydration lowers water activity and spoilage risk, allowing peppers to keep safely for nearly a year.

Adult: Dried peppers properly cured and stored at room temperature have extended shelf life due to low moisture content

preventing microbial growth.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables